Alistair and the Mist-Mending Jar

By Kshipra

It was a grey afternoon in the Hundred Acre Wood, and Alistair felt like he was walking through knee-deep water. His favorite bright yellow kite, the one that could dance with the clouds, was tangled high in the reach of an old, grumpy oak tree. He had tried to pull it down, but the string snapped, leaving the kite stranded. Alistair didn't want to stomp or shout; he just felt a heavy, quiet ache in his chest that made his

Alistair sat down on a mossy log. He felt like a rainy day was happening inside of him. Every time he thought about his kite, a big, shaky sigh escaped his lips. He didn't want to go home, and he didn't want to play. He just

A soft rustle came from the bushes, and Wilfred, a gentle golden-furred bear wearing a small red shirt, waddled into the clearing. He saw Alistair's drooping head and the way the air around him seemed a little bit darker.

"Sadness is like a fog, Alistair," Wilfred said in his slow, honey-sweet voice. "If you try to run through it, you might get lost. If you hide from it, it follows you. You need the 'Mist-Mending Jar'!" Wilfred pulled out a clear glass jar. It had a

"Give it your sighs," Wilfred whispered. "Let the heavy air out so you have room for the light air." Alistair took a deep breath, but instead of blowing hard like he was at a birthday party, he let out a long, slow sigh right into the jar. He

As the jar caught the mist, it began to swirl with beautiful shades of blue and purple. Alistair took another breath, and then another. With each sigh, the weight in his chest felt a little less like a heavy rock and a little more like a soft

As they walked through the woods, they found Mica, a small rabbit with long, floppy ears, sitting by the stream. Mica was crying because she had dropped her favorite carved wooden carrot into the rushing water. Alistair felt a pang of

Mica breathed her own sighs into the jar, and soon it was glowing so brightly it looked like a captured piece of the night sky. "Wait," Wilfred cautioned, looking at the swirling mist. "When the jar is this full, the sadness must be shared with

Alistair and Mica watched the glowing droplets until they disappeared around the bend. They didn't have their kite or their wooden carrot back, but they had each other. They decided to spend the rest of the afternoon making boats out of fallen leaves. Alistair realized that being sad was just a part of the journey, and it was much easier to carry when you had a friend and a way to let the mist out.